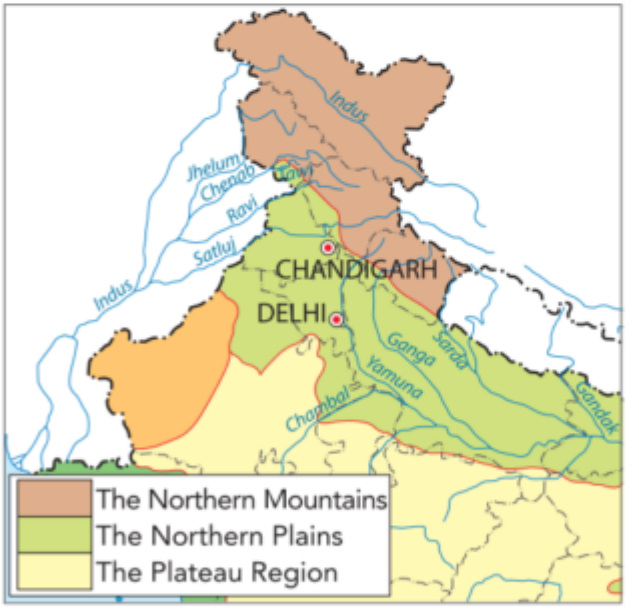
10 Political Divisions of North India

Topics covered

- Summary of information
- Divisions in the mountains
- Divisions in the northern plains

Use the map on page 72 to help you identify the states/union territories. Find out in which natural region they are. Colour the boxes accordingly. Use more than one colour if the state/union territory lies in more than one natural region.

Jammu and Kashmir (Union Territory) ☐
Ladakh (Union Territory) ☐
Himachal Pradesh ☐
Uttarakhand ☐
Chandigarh (Union Territory) ☐
Punjab ☐
Haryana ☐
Delhi – National Capital Territory ☐
Uttar Pradesh ☐



The divisions in the northern part of India are both in the mountains and the plains. There are states and union territories. The table on the next page gives you a quick view of these states and union territories.

State/UT	Capital and some cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Jammu and Kashmir	Srinagar—Summer capital Jammu—Winter capital Gulmarg, Pahalgam	Jhelum, Chenab, Tawi	Coniferous trees, grassy slopes, chinar trees	Rice, wheat, saffron, fruit	Agriculture, handicrafts
Ladakh	Leh—capital	Indus	Patches of grass and shrubs, willow, poplar	Barley, wheat	Agriculture, livestock rearing (yaks, goats, sheep), weaving of pashmina shawls, carpet and rugs
Himachal Pradesh	Shimla—capital Kullu, Manali, Dharamshala, Kangra	Chenab, Ravi, Beas, Satluj	Abundant green vegetation, pine, deodar and sal	Wheat, maize, potatoes, fruit	Farming, fruit preservation, offices
Uttarakhand	Dehra Dun—capital Mussourie, Nainital Haridwar	Ganga, Yamuna, Alaknanda, Bhagirathi	Grassy slopes and flowers, deciduous and thorn forests	Potatoes, maize, fruit	Agriculture, dairy farming, working in various industries
Chandigarh	Union territory				Working in government offices and factories
Punjab	Chandigarh—capital Amritsar, Ludhiana	Ravi, Beas, Satluj	Forests cleared to make fields	Wheat, rice, cotton, mustard	Farming, dairy farming, woollen garment making, and working in factories
Haryana	Chandigarh—capital Faridabad, Kurukshetra, Panipat	Yamuna, Ghaggar	Not much natural vegetation, some scrub vegetation in southern part	Wheat, rice, cotton	Agriculture, dairy farming and working in factories
Delhi	Delhi and New Delhi	Yamuna		Wheat, vegetables	Working in government and other offices
Uttar Pradesh	Lucknow—capital Agra, Varanasi, Allahabad, Kanpur	Ganga, Yamuna, Gomti	Most natural vegetation cleared to grow crops, small southern part has scrub vegetation	Wheat, rice, maize sugar cane, mangoes	Agriculture, working in offices and factories, tourism, handicrafts

MOUNTAIN STATES/UNION TERRITORIES

Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand lie in the mountainous parts of India. In the lower mountains and hills, the winter is cold but the summer is cool. There is rain in the monsoon season. The highest mountains are always very cold as they are snow-covered.

Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir

Chinar trees in autumn—the leaves turn red before falling. Inset—the beautiful chinar leaf design is used in handicrafts. Notice the different colours of the fallen leaves.

Capital and other cities: Jammu and Kashmir has two capitals—Srinagar is the summer capital and Jammu is the winter capital. Gulmarg, a popular skiing spot in Jammu and Kashmir, and Pahalgham, get a lot of tourists.

Rivers: There are two major rivers in Jammu and Kashmir. The Jhelum has Srinagar on its banks and the Tawi flows through the city of Jammu.

Natural vegetation: There are coniferous trees, grassy slopes as well as rocky land on which nothing grows. The beautiful chinar trees are found in plenty.

Saffron flowers in the field—each saffron flower has three orange stigmas that are dried and used as a spice.

Crops: Rice and wheat are grown on terraced fields. Hill slopes are cut into **terraces** or steps to make fields on which to grow crops. Saffron, an expensive spice used in dishes like pulao, is grown in Kashmir. There are orchards where fruits like cherries, peaches, apples, almonds and walnuts are grown. These are eaten as healthy snacks and sold in other parts of India and the world.

Occupation: The main occupations are agriculture and handicrafts.

Union Territory of Ladakh

Capital and other cities: The capital of Ladakh is Leh. Ladakh is considered the highest altitude plateau region in India, covering parts of the Himalayan and Karakoram mountain ranges and the upper Indus River valley. The climate is very cold and dry in Ladakh as it gets very little rainfall.

River: The Indus is the main river flowing through the territory of Ladakh.

Natural vegetation: Grasses and shrubs cover a large area. Willow and poplar trees grow here.

Crops: Barley and wheat are important crops grown here.

Occupation: Agriculture and handicrafts are the main occupations of the people in this region.

Did you Know?

The Himsagar (him - snow, sagar-ocean) Express goes from Jammu Tawi station to Kanniyakumari on the southern tip of India. It takes almost three days for the journey and stops at 73 stations on the way.

Think and answer

Why do you think houses in the mountain regions have sloping roofs?

Natural vegetation of trees and green shrubs gives Himachal Pradesh its beauty.

Himachal Pradesh

Capital and other cities: Shimla is the capital of Himachal Pradesh. Kullu, Manali, Kangra, and Kufri are popular tourist places for their natural beauty. Dharamshala is an important town for many Buddhists.

The Beas River in the Kullu valley

Rivers: The Satluj, Beas and Ravi flow fast down the slopes of the hilly region.

Natural vegetation: The state has abundant green vegetation because of its hilly climate. Tall trees of pine, deodar and sal are found here. The wood is used for fuel and also to make furniture and handicrafts.

Crops: Wheat, maize (corn) and potatoes are grown in plenty. The state is known for its delicious fruits like apricots, plums, peaches and apples. Various kinds of flowers are also grown.

Occupation: Farming is the main occupation. People also work in small factories that make jams and juices.

The beautiful Valley of Flowers

Uttarakhand

Capital and other cities: Dehra Dun, the capital city, is in the Doon Valley. Mussourie and Nainital are popular hill towns here. Haridwar is a holy city.

Rivers: The Ganga, Yamuna, Alaknanda and Bhagirathi, and several others flow through the state.

Natural vegetation: The natural vegetation depends on the height of the land. High mountains are rocky and snow-covered, while lower down there are grassy slopes and flowers. Even lower, there are deciduous and thorn forests.

Crops: Potatoes, maize and different kinds of fruit are grown here.

Occupation: Most people are engaged in farming that is done on terraced fields, as well as in juice and jam-making.

Terrace farming in Uttarakhand

DIVISIONS IN THE PLAINS

The union territory of Chandigarh, Delhi, states of Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, are all situated in the Great Northern Plain. This is a vast flat land lying south of the Himalayas.

Summer is very hot all over the plains with hot winds and dust storms in some places. In the western part of the northern plain, the monsoon rains are not very heavy. Winters are very cold in this part of the northern plain.

Union Territory of Chandigarh

Chandigarh is the capital of two states—Punjab and Haryana. It is the first planned city in India. It got its name from the Chandi Mandir near the city. The city is divided into **sectors**. Each sector has its own shops, gardens and other common facilities. Schools and hospitals are spread all over the city. Straight roads divide the sectors and form a grid.

Two famous gardens in Chandigarh are the Rose Garden and the Rock Garden. The Rose Garden has hundreds of varieties of roses and looks very beautiful when they bloom.

The Rock Garden was created by Nek Chand Saini from waste materials like broken crockery, bangles, electrical fittings, tyres and other such waste.

Sculptures made out of broken glass bangles in the Rock Garden

Punjab

A part of the Golden Temple is covered with real gold.

Capital and other cities: The capital city is Chandigarh. Other important cities are Amritsar which is famous for the Golden Temple (gurdwara for the Sikhs) and Ludhiana that makes knitted garments and cycles.

Rivers: Punjab means 'five waters'. The five rivers that flowed through undivided Punjab (Punjab was divided between India and Pakistan at the time of Independence) are the Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Satluj. The Ravi, Beas and Satluj still flow through Punjab in India.

Ripe wheat crop—the wheat grains are in the cluster at the end of the plant.

Natural vegetation: Like in other parts of the northern plain, the forests have been cleared to make fields. The state has vast areas of flat fields with **fertile** soil ideal for growing crops.

Crops: Wheat is cultivated in large quantities. Rice is grown too. Other crops are cotton and mustard.

Occupation: Farming is the largest occupation. **Dairy farming,** where cattle are kept for their milk products like curd, butter and cottage cheese (paneer), is common. People also work in factories that make tractors, machinery and cycles.

Haryana

A stall at the annual crafts fair at Surajkund which attracts a lot of people

Capital and other cities: Chandigarh is the capital city of Haryana which it shares with Punjab. Faridabad is known for its industries. Panipat is a historical town while Kurukshetra is an important pilgrimage centre.

Rivers: The river Yamuna forms the border between Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. The Ghaggar flows through the northern edge of the state. The rest of the land is watered by canals that bring water from Punjab.

Natural vegetation: Not much natural vegetation remains in Haryana, as much of the land is used to grow crops. The southern part of the state has some scrub vegetation while in the northern part of the state, trees of different kinds have been planted along the roads and canals.

Crops: Wheat, rice and cotton are grown in most parts of the state.

Occupation: As in all states of the plains, agriculture is the main occupation. Many farmers also keep cows and buffaloes for milk and milk products. People in the towns also work in the many factories there.

Water buffaloes are a common sight in Haryana.

Delhi

Capital and other cities: Delhi is different from other states of the country. It has the capital of our country, New Delhi. Delhi and New Delhi together are one big city. There is a state government but the Government of India also has some responsibilities for the state. Gurgaon in Haryana and Noida in Uttar Pradesh are very close to Delhi. People travel to and from work between these cities and Delhi.

Rivers: Delhi is situated on the banks of the Yamuna.

The Qutb Minar is one of the largest stone structures in the world.

The Rashtrapati Bhavan—residence of the President of India.

Crops: Crops like wheat and vegetables are grown in some areas.

Important places: Delhi is an old city that has many significant buildings. The Qutb Minar, the Red Fort and the Jama Masjid are historical buildings. Sansad Bhavan (Parliament House) and Rashtrapati Bhavan are government buildings.

Occupation: A lot of people in Delhi work in the many government offices here. There are also several media and newspaper offices where many people work. Others work in the universities, various educational centres and different kinds of offices.

Uttar Pradesh

Early morning at Varanasi on the banks of the Ganga

A hand pump to draw up underground water—such pumps are seen in several places in this region.

Capital and other cities: Lucknow is a historical city with beautiful old monuments and is the capital of Uttar Pradesh (UP). It is also famous for its beautiful embroidery work. The city of Agra has the famous monument, the Taj Mahal, made of white marble and precious stones. It was built by Shah Jahan on the banks of the Yamuna. Kanpur has many industries and is an important town. The holy cities of Varanasi and Allahabad on the Ganga are visited by millions of people.

Rivers: The Ganga and its tributary the Gomti flow through the state. The Yamuna also flows here.

Natural vegetation: Most of the land in Uttar Pradesh has been cleared of natural vegetation to grow crops. A small southern part of the state has higher land. Here it is quite dry so there is some scrub vegetation.

Crops: Wheat, sugar cane, rice and maize are the main crops. Mangoes are also grown in plenty.

Occupation: Agriculture, working in factories and offices, tourism and handicrafts are some of the important occupations.

Discuss

Where would you choose to live—in the mountains or the plains? Why?

Values and Life Skills

Mountain regions have many pretty towns and other places where people live and others visit. How can we keep these places clean and beautiful always?

REMEMBER

1. States in the northern part of India are spread across both mountains and plains.
2. The mountain regions have fast flowing rivers, tall trees, grassy slopes and snow in winter and are naturally beautiful.
3. The plains have green fertile fields and large rivers. Winter is cold, but summer is hot.

NEW WORDS

Terraces	series of flat areas on a slope, which look like steps, and are used for growing crops
Sector	an area or portion that is distinct from others
Fertile	land or soil in which plants grow well
Dairy farming	a farm where cows and buffaloes are kept to produce milk

EXERCISES

A. Who am I?

1. An expensive spice grown in Kashmir .....
2. A city that is the capital of two states .....
3. A city that has the Golden Temple .....
4. A famous monument made of white marble .....
5. A city that is famous for its embroidery .....

B. Pick the odd one out.

Say why it is different.

1. Jammu and Kashmir, Haryana, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh
2. Dharamshala, Varanasi, Ludhiana, Allahabad
3. Kufri, Kanpur, Gulmarg, Nainital
4. Mustard, wheat, maize, apples
5. Shimla, Dehra Dun, Panipat, Jammu

C. Crossword

Write the clues for this rivers crossword in your notebook.

D. Write true or false.

Say why they are false.

1. Srinagar is the only capital of Jammu and Kashmir.
2. Leh is one of the highest cities in India.
3. The Jama Masjid is in Himachal Pradesh.
4. The Rock Garden in Chandigarh is made of flowers and pebbles.
5. Dharamshala is an important town for Buddhists.

E. Answer the following questions.

1. Why is jam-making an important occupation in the mountain states?
2. What is alluvium? Why is it important?
3. What is interesting about saffron?
4. Give two ways in which Chandigarh is different from other cities.
5. What does the name Punjab mean? Name the rivers from which it gets its name.
6. How are the water buffaloes useful to the farmers in Haryana?
7. Why does Delhi have many government buildings?
8. Which is the most well-known monument in Uttar Pradesh? Write a few sentences about it.

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THINGS TO DO

A. Picture study

These are places in the northern plains, visited by many people. Talk about what is special about them and find out more about them.

1. Jallianwala Bagh – Punjab 2. Raj Ghat – Delhi 3. Gate of Fatehpur Sikri– Uttar Pradesh 4. Pinjore Gardens – Haryana

1.

2.

3.

4.

SI

B. On your own

Make your own fruit chaat! This is popular in the northern states.

Chop guavas, apples, pineapples, and bananas into small cubes. Add lime juice, salt, zeera powder and mix well. Chill and enjoy!

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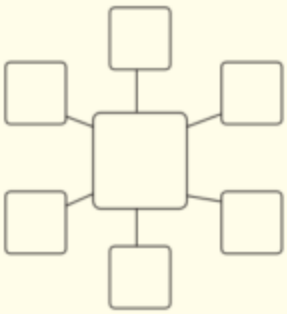
C. In a group

Divide yourselves into groups of four or five and make a pen picture (description in words) of the states that you have learnt about. Use the template given to help you do this. Write the name of the state in the centre and the details in the boxes around it.



WEBLINK

Panorama of northern India: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bpW1wsOSXGo (accessed on 27 July 2017)